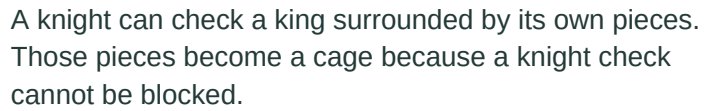


Smothered mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: queen on d3. Check for tactical protection.

Previous move: 28.Qxd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

28...Qg1+ 29. Rxg1 Nf2#

28...Qg1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From g1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on f1. Recorded reply:
29.Rxg1.

29...Nf2# Mate: knight on f2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on f2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.